

KPI Quick Start for Technology Leaders

From Activity Counts to Actionable Scorecards

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Audience: K-12 CTOs, CIOs, Technology Directors, IT Directors, and aspiring district technology leaders

Purpose: Turn operational data into an actionable scorecard for leadership decisions.

GenAI data guardrail: Use fictional, public, aggregated, or properly sanitized information with public generative AI tools. Do not enter student records, staff records, personally identifiable information, credentials, sensitive cybersecurity details, legal records, confidential procurement material, vendor-confidential information, or sensitive district project information unless your district has explicitly approved the tool and data use.

Metric vs. KPI

A **metric** is a measurement. A **KPI** is a measurement selected because it shows whether a strategic result, service expectation, or project outcome is moving in the intended direction.

Example	What It Is	Why
1,268 tickets closed	Activity/output metric	Shows volume, but not whether users received timely service
91% of priority-2 tickets resolved within SLA	KPI	Connects performance to an agreed service expectation
437 devices installed	Activity/output metric	Shows work completed, but not progress against the rollout plan
87% of the summer device milestone completed by target date	KPI	Connects work to schedule and a defined project result
22 training sessions offered	Activity metric	Counts effort

Example	What It Is	Why
84% of intended users demonstrate the new workflow without assistance	Adoption KPI	Shows whether the change is becoming usable practice

The KPI Design Chain

Goal -> Leadership Question -> KPI -> Baseline -> Target -> Owner -> Action

Worked Example

Element	Ardent ISD Example
Goal	Improve classroom technology support
Leadership question	Are teachers receiving meaningful support quickly enough?
KPI	Priority-2 tickets resolved within 8 business hours
Baseline	71%
Target	90%
Owner	Director of Technical Services
Action threshold	Below 80% for two consecutive reporting periods triggers workload and process review

Eight Characteristics of a Useful KPI

1. **Relevant:** It answers a real leadership question.
2. **Defined:** People can calculate it the same way each time.
3. **Owned:** Someone is accountable for monitoring and responding.
4. **Timely:** It updates often enough to support a decision.
5. **Comparable:** A baseline, target, trend, or benchmark gives the number meaning.
6. **Actionable:** The district knows what it will do when the KPI moves.
7. **Understandable:** A nontechnical leader can interpret it without a glossary.
8. **Sustainable:** The cost of collecting the data is worth the decision value.

KPI Types Technology Leaders Should Recognize

Type	Leadership Use	Example
Input	What resources are being invested?	Device-refresh funding committed
Process	Is the work moving efficiently?	Median account-provisioning time
Output	What was produced?	Devices staged
Outcome	What changed as a result?	Device readiness during instruction
Leading	What may predict future performance?	Training completion before rollout
Lagging	What result already occurred?	90-day sustained adoption
Quantitative	What can be counted?	Network availability
Qualitative	What do stakeholders report?	Principal confidence pulse

Start Small

For a first executive dashboard, choose **8-15 KPIs** rather than every metric the department can produce. Separate outcome indicators from activity indicators. A smaller dashboard forces the team to decide what matters most.

Monthly KPI Review Routine

1. Verify the source and reporting period.
2. Check whether the formula or population changed.
3. Compare current value with baseline, target, and prior period.
4. Ask what evidence explains the change.
5. Identify the owner and next action for off-target items.
6. Record the decision, not just the number.
7. Retire or replace KPIs that no longer influence decisions.

GenAI Prompt: Recommend KPIs

You are helping a K-12 technology director design key performance indicators.

Project or service:
[DESCRIBE IT]

Strategic goal:

[GOAL]

Primary audience:

[CTO / cabinet / principals / board / technology staff]

Available data:

[LIST SANITIZED DATA SOURCES OR FIELDS]

Recommend no more than 8 KPIs.

For each KPI provide:

1. KPI name
2. Leadership question it answers
3. Definition
4. Formula
5. Desired direction: higher, lower, or target range
6. Suggested baseline approach
7. Example target, clearly labeled as illustrative
8. Data source
9. Update frequency
10. Owner
11. Action that should occur when performance is outside the target

Separate leading indicators from lagging indicators.

Do not invent district performance data.

Source and Alignment Notes

This sample library is designed as a companion to **Module 8: Project Management and Change Leadership** in the TCEA Technology/IT Director Certification. It extends the module's emphasis on desired outcomes, progress reporting, KPIs, dashboards, communication, change adoption, and responsible generative AI use.

Useful reference points:

- Make Data Displays Without Writing Code - TCEA TechNotes article on GenAI-assisted data displays, dashboard workflows, Google Sheets, GitHub Pages, and embedding.
- KPI Dashboards Built with Gen AI - TCEA TechNotes article demonstrating a browser-based dashboard paired with an editable Markdown data file.
- Metrics and KPIs Made Easy - TCEA TechNotes introduction to actionable KPI scorecards for technology leaders.
- K-12 KPI Dashboard Generator - browser-based KPI planning and dashboard starter.
- District KPI Dashboard Example - example of a scoreboard-style district dashboard.
- Data Display Patterns Field Guide - examples, prompts, and hosting considerations for lightweight visual displays.

Data note: Every Ardent ISD number in this library is illustrative sample data. Replace it with locally verified data before operational use.